

household debt that had to be paid postmortem. Before there were funeral homes, people buried each other for free, so nobody had an automatic reason to fear insolvency after death.

From what I could gather, both the financial planning industry and the life insurance industry owe a big thank-you to the organized morticians. The earliest life insurance for the masses was introduced as a way of paying off funeral bills. From there, the coverage was gradually expanded to benefit the surviving members of the family. As the average person began living longer and longer, newer forms of life insurance provided benefits to policyholders even before they'd died, or in industry parlance, while they were predeceased. Thus did the notion of a financial future work its way up from the burial fee, through the maintenance of the bereaved, finally to become a goal that an average person could hope to attain while he or she was fully conscious.

Now we've got Social Security, pension plans, profit-sharing plans, annuities, Keoghs, and IRAs—all of which complicate the financial future to the point where we can hardly stand to think about it. These complications have given thousands of new planners the opportunity to offer their help.

From out of my yellow pages, I picked a reputable-sounding name: M. H. Senzel & Co. I called up and made an appointment for the free introductory consultation. M. H. Senzel occupied a seventh-floor suite in a large concrete building near a freeway in my town. The waiting room was right out of a doctor's office, except that instead of *Newsweek* or *People* on the coffee table there was a *Money* and a *Forbes*. I sat a few minutes reading the *Money* until an earnest young fellow in a sport coat and leisure slacks appeared. He introduced himself as Boyd Leffert.

Mr. Leffert led me through a hallway into a conference room and motioned me to sit in a chair midway down a long table. He set up a vinyl display board that had been leaning against a wall and picked up a felt-tipped pointer from the table. He stood by the display board and drew things on it with the pointer as we chatted.

The first thing Mr. Leffert wanted to talk about was the "universe of financial planners," which now includes more than 200,000 in this country alone. Apparently, there are twice as many of these